all I did was walk into a sprawling apartment with all my things beautifully set up for me.

On the morning of 26 January 2001, just ten months after we had moved into the new apartment, I heard Anjali screaming in fear, yelling 'Earthquake!' The building was swaying from side to side and my first thought was that the builder must have messed up with the construction. However, within moments I realized that it was far more serious than that and people from nearby buildings were all screaming '*Bhago, bhago!*' (Run, run!) Because we were on the tenth and eleventh floors, it would have taken us a few minutes to walk down with two kids, so all we did was stand in the middle of the drawing room, huddled together as a family, praying for the catastrophe to stop.

The earthquake that rocked Western India lasted less than a minute, but it left devastation in its wake. The town of Bhuj in Gujarat was almost destroyed and we in Mumbai did not escape unscathed. From my bedroom at La Mer I could see Mount Mary Church on the one side and Siddhivinayak Temple on the other and for days after the earthquake I would pray at night, urging God never to unleash such wrath on us again.

In fact, even when I played a Duleep Trophy match in Pune for West Zone against East Zone in early February, I still could not sleep properly at night. The nightmare of the quake was too fresh to forget. In Pune we were staying in an ordinary hotel but the staff did everything possible to make things comfortable for me. In fact, they overdid things on occasions and were themselves embarrassed as a result. To ensure we all had hot water, the maintenance person had switched on the boiler very early in the morning. As a result, the boiler overheated and all we ended up with was black muddy water in the room. Being used to staying in five-star hotels, initially I was irritated with the hotel staff, but later I found it funny that they were trying so hard to make me comfortable. The effort was overwhelming and left a lasting impression.

Soon after the end of the Duleep Trophy game, in which I scored 199 in our only innings, a number of journalists asked me if we stood a chance against Australia. I said we did and felt confident we could beat them, provided we were able to put them under pressure. It seemed to me they weren't accustomed to handling pressure and it would be interesting to see how they reacted if we gained the upper hand.

First Test, Mumbai, 27 February–1 March 2001